whose origin lies in the arrival of substantial numbers of guest workers.) The fact that Eastern Europe does not have a colonial experience also means that it 'thus lacks a sense of guilt, but it also lacks a shared fate that often accompanies colonial encounters.'[132]

It was not only xenophobia, but genuine concern about how Central Europe could possibly succeed where the likes of the Netherlands, Germany and Sweden had failed. In April 2022, the Swedish Social Democratic Prime Minister conceded what others had been observing for a long time: that its integration policies have failed.[133] This became the key topic of the general elections that same year which propelled the Sweden Democrats to the position of a kingmaker of the new government. (To be fair, there is also a failure of Eastern Europe itself to deal with its own Roma population,[134] who are not immigrants.) And there was probably also a feeling that accommodating and integrating large numbers of migrants would take a toll on Central Europe's race to catch up with Western Europe.

In any event, the region's reaction to the refugee crisis cemented a view of it as an alien, xenophobic and anti-immigrant, socially conservative part of Europe – 'illiberal Europe', an image that will have been only partially corrected with the overwhelming welcome given to millions of war refugees from Ukraine in 2022, during a migrant wave much bigger than the one of 2015-2016. But not even this has taken away the negative image of illiberal Europe.

Ivan Krastev, probably one of the region's best analysts, cites possible explanations for Eastern fear about migrants. One of them is depopulation (which hit Bulgaria, Romania and the Baltics in particular), as a result of free movement of labour. According to Krastev, the fear of depopulation has been substituted with the fear of (Muslim) foreigners. Related to it is the experience of these same Central European expats, who in the West often end up living in the same neighbourhoods as Muslims, and therefore want to disassociate from them. But most importantly, '[t]he refugee crisis has made it clear that Eastern Europe views the very cosmopolitan values on which the European Union is based as a threat, while for many in the West it is precisely those cosmopolitan values that are at the core of the new European identity.[135] […] The resistance of liberals to conceding any negative effects of migration has triggered the anti-establishment (and particularly anti-mainstream media) reaction that is convulsing political life